

Metallurgist

I am reminded that brilliance rarely announces itself properly.

Chauncy returned from Eitheloth this morning with a metalworker in tow. Purposefully he is *not* one of my previous contacts, the grand masters whose names are carved into Conservatory plaques, but a young naive furnace worker from the fortress's subterranean chambers. For a nobleman, the Lord Gilibard of the peripheral house Silarin nonetheless has the industrious focus and quiet humility of a practical man from practical stock. Chauncy assures me he has discretion as well, no doubt learned under Eitheloth's militaristic umbra. I've done my best to make him comfortable in this dismal place, but there's only so much one can do with a damp tower as one lonely occupant. I have large enough plans in that respect, and I deign to say this metallurgist may prove quite helpful in that endeavor.

We spoke at length about proper furnace temperature, which impurities to seek out in a good feedstock, how to avoid stress fractures in enchanted alloys. At first I tested him gently; simple questions about heat gradients, sympathetic resonance, the behavior of metals under sustained enchantment. He answered plainly, without embroidery, and even corrected me once. I allowed it.

Only later did I bring out my sketches. Not the whole design, never the whole design, but enough to explain the problem: a casing that must endure constant motion and several degrees of interplanar resonance, furthermore it must not be allowed to feed back on any of these arcane signals (in the way that common steel or bronze would) in order to keep the device stable. He studied the drawings as if they literature and proceeded to pepper me with an impressive line of questioning. He asked where it would fail first, and what I feared would happen if it did. By the end of our conversation he seems to have worked out a brass alloy which "listens," for lack of a better word. He did not specify a composition but instead focused on the timing for quenching and resting in the way a craftsman can only truly understand.

I paid him very well for a prototype and his silence about our meeting before providing a speedy journey home via an improvised teleportation circle (let this be a reminder to build a permanent chamber). Eitheloth continues to surprise me. Whereas Elga Elluin produces theorists and artists and elves who die gloriously for their footnotes, Eitheloth produces tools. The Convocation looks down on that city for precisely this reason.

I will have Chauncy keep the channel open. If this idea of mine survives its infancy, I suspect I will need that furnace again.